

fine—as long as he hands you your rightful half of the family fortune.

Money Mistake: A Midlife Crisis Threatens

The Fix: *Save the Dynasty at All Costs*

Ah, the midlife crisis—the Achilles’ heel for men of a certain age. We’ve all seen it happen. Half my friends are divorced, some of them multiple times. After watching these guys enter into second, third and even fourth marriages, I’ve come to realize that their partners are not the problem; it’s *them*. What they fail to realize is that the bling-bling of youth and beauty vanishes faster than a mirage in the desert. The payoff is in the dynasty, not the 20-year-old girlfriend. But so many guys lose their heads—and then they lose their wallets, too.

Take my friend, for instance. We’ll call him Mark. Mark is something of a legend in Boston: he’s had four partners (though technically only three wives) and *six children*. I don’t even advocate having six kids with *one* partner, let alone four! The guy is embroiled in lawsuits every day! His ex-wives all know each other—they call themselves the Ex-Mark’s Club—and every one of them is intent on clawing a piece of Mark’s financial dynasty. Oh, and these women aren’t gold diggers; they’re moms. You can’t blame them for wanting to secure a future for their children, even if their future with Mark didn’t pan out.

Mark is only 45 years old. He should be stabilizing his empire, not dividing it into pieces. But every time he gets divorced, he suffers from a geometric decrease in wealth, because each wife takes her deserved half. All the Ex-Marks are suing for child support, too, and rightly so. This makes Mark’s life incredibly complicated.

Mark is a charming guy, so I can see why women fall for him. He’s a wealthy entrepreneur, offering each new partner the illusion of ease and security. The irony is that they really do get a lifetime of ease and security, at least financially, even after Mark has moved on, because he’s forced to leave half of everything behind.